



MENTAL STRENGTH

Keeping Things in Perspective

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28%

of respondents reported difficulties
in maintaining perspective

92%

respondents with **high levels** of
resilience have keeping things in
perspective as a strength

62%

respondents with **average levels**
of resilience have keeping things
in perspective as a strength

17%

respondents with **low levels** of
resilience have keeping things
in perspective as a strength



Keeping Things in Perspective

'To think about a situation in a reasonable way and judge its real importance by considering it in relation to everything else.'

SCENARIO

Your project deadline has been brought forward by the customer, halving the amount of time you have until submission.

- ① What would your reaction be?
- ② What impact does this have?
- ③ How could you regain perspective?

What would your reaction be?

Panic, frustration, rant, complaining to colleagues

What impact does this have?

Creates an environment of crisis

How could you regain perspective?

Discuss with the customer, understand their perspective, agree priorities and areas to descope.

Key Factors That Impact Perspective

In the previous example, what are the key factors that impact your perspective and therefore how you react to being told that a project you are working on needs to be done in half the time?



CLARITY OF INFORMATION

Why the deadline has been brought forward, what the customer's expectations are, whether you will get more resources? Complete and accurate information enables a more informed evaluation.



PERSONAL BIASES, BELIEFS & PAST EXPERIENCES

Can influence interpretation of the situation and perspective – I won't do a good job, I won't be able to cope.



EMOTIONAL STATE

Stress, frustration, low self-esteem, can affect perception and affect judgement.



EXPERIENCE & EXPERTISE IN THE PROJECT AREA

Can impact your assessment of the situation, greater experience may help in understanding the context and the potential implications.



ORGANISATIONAL CULTURE, VALUES, NORMS AND RISK TOLERANCE

Can influence how you consider the challenge will be perceived and evaluated within the organisation.



RESOURCE AVAILABILITY

If these can be increased in line with the shortened deadline there will be reduced impact.



COMMUNICATION CHANNELS

Clear and open communication fosters better understanding and assessment.



These factors interact dynamically, shaping your ability to maintain perspective.

How To Regain Perspective



QUANTIFY THE SEVERITY ON A SCALE OF 1 – 10

If 1 is a minor setback and 10 is a major event, this situation might sit around a 3-4.



WHAT IS THE WORST THAT COULD HAPPEN?

The management/customer isn't happy with the quality and finish, the project will have to be re-worked.



WHAT WOULD BE A REASONABLE REACTION?

Mild annoyance and frustration.



CAN THIS SITUATION BE PREVENTED IN FUTURE?

Recognise that project deadlines change, and having a regular cadence with the customer will enable you to identify future challenges ahead.

The Process of Losing Perspective



OVERREACTION

Constant pressure at work or home can lead to a regular overreaction to events, which is draining, demoralising and creates a feeling of lack of control.



LOSS OF PERSPECTIVE

In this permanent high-adrenaline state, disproportionate importance is given to minor events, resulting in a loss of perspective.



PANIC

Energy and focus switches to managing the symptoms rather than the cause, creating an atmosphere of mild panic and physiological symptoms such as fatigue, muscle tension, anger, irritability, headache and anxiety.



POOR JUDGEMENT

This loss of perspective and crisis mode can affect our day-to-day time management. We tend to spend time on perceived 'urgent' work to the detriment / at the cost of important non-urgent tasks.



HEALTH RISKS

Long-term persistent adrenaline surges can damage your blood vessels, increase your blood pressure, elevate your risk of heart attack or strokes, in addition to weight gain and insomnia.

Regaining Perspective at Work

Regaining perspective at work involves stepping back from the immediate situation, reassessing it from a broader viewpoint, and gaining clarity on the key aspects and implications.



Strategies to regain perspective include:

Taking short breaks, seeking input from others, practicing mindfulness, maintaining a healthy work-life balance, fostering a culture of open communication and collaboration in the workplace.



By keeping things in perspective, we can:

- Develop a better understanding of things and gain greater clarity.
- See a problem or challenge from different angles to develop better knowledge and empathy.
- Evaluate the importance of something and how it fits into the big picture.
- Keep worries or thoughts in perspective and reduce stress.
- Let go of judgement and focus on facts.
- Keep things in a more balanced viewpoint.
- See the strengths and weaknesses / good and bad / positive and negative.
- React rationally, considerately, and constructively rather than impulsively.
- Be objective, unbiased and empathetic.
- See challenges as opportunities for learning and personal growth.

Developing Your Sense of Perspective



UNDERSTAND YOUR STRENGTHS

Understand your strengths and identify the positive aspects of your work.



REFLECT ON WHAT HAS GONE WELL AND WHY

Then focus on applying these positive working practices to other situations.



PUT A POSITIVE SPIN ON THINGS

Acknowledge the successes of your day rather than the aspects that went less well.



CHOOSE YOUR BATTLES

Concentrate your efforts on the important issues and let the small things go.



AVOID GOING OVER FRUSTRATIONS

Instead, think about them, decide what you can learn from them, discuss with colleagues, mentors and friends if it helps you gain perspective, then move on.



DISTINGUISH URGENT FROM IMPORTANT

Distinguish between urgent tasks and important tasks (the Eisenhower Principle). An email headed 'urgent' may not actually have higher priority than a long-term or strategic issue.

When Things Don't Work Out as You Had Planned



THINK BEYOND

Think beyond the moment to how this issue will look in a week's / month's time.



FORGIVE MINOR SETBACKS

Treat minor setbacks as just that and don't let them impact your self-esteem



ANALYSE YOUR EXPECTATIONS

Establish what your expectations were, whether they were unrealistic and resolve to set more realistic targets next time.



REVIEW OBJECTIVELY

Establish what the actual result was and remain objective, bearing in mind it's unlikely everything went wrong. See the positives from the situation and identify any actions needed to rectify the outcome.



ANALYSE THE EXPECTATIONS OF OTHERS

Consider what other people's expectations were. You may be surprised to find they had lower expectations and therefore do not perceive a problem with the outcome.



ADJUST

Decide what you would do again, wouldn't do again, and what you could do differently to improve the outcome. Hopefully you will see that the majority of what you did was correct and that with a few small changes you can do better in the future.

Keeping Things in Perspective



EXERCISE 1

Develop the ability to keep things in perspective

The following exercise - for individuals or groups - is based on The Six Thinking Hats principle, a concept developed by Edward de Bono. Applying this method can be instrumental in maintaining perspective. This offers a structured approach to thinking and problem-solving by considering different perspectives through the lens of 6 hats.



BLUE HAT

Conductor

Organisation & Planning,
big picture perspective,
action plan



WHITE HAT

Reason

Facts, figures,
information



BLACK HAT

Devil's Advocate

Risks, Consequences,
Difficulties, Roadblocks



GREEN HAT

Creative Thinker

Creative thinking, new
ideas, out-of-the-box
thinking



RED HAT

Instinctive

Feelings & Instinct



YELLOW HAT

Optimistic

Benefits & Values

Key strategies for achieving a better outcome:



Structure your discussion so that all participants collectively explore the problem using each of the Six Thinking Hats.



Have everyone focus on the same hat simultaneously to promote parallel thinking rather than adversarial.



Resist the urge to criticise or dismiss ideas; instead, concentrate on generating creative alternatives.